there with burial mounds and relics of China’s ancient past—made for a day we’ll long remember.”

We had asked to visit one of China’s new free markets where Chinese farmers and entrepreneurs could sell items for profit in a departure from Communist ideology. At first the Chinese officials said that it would be impractical because of security restrictions, but then they offered to set up a sample market, and Nancy bought several decorations for our Christmas tree and presents for our grandchildren from a young girl there. Nancy’s bill came to five yuan, about $2.50. I handed the girl a ten-yuan note, and when she discovered she didn’t have any change, she looked around, flustered and embarrassed, searching for help.

I’d been briefed that tipping was not customary in China, but I felt sorry for her as she looked around in panic for help, so I said, “Keep it,” and we moved on. But in a few moments she caught up with us and handed me my change, which somehow she had managed to find.

By then, I was the embarrassed one. I realized that, in trying to be helpful to the girl, I’d appeared to be tipping her. I hadn’t thought fast enough and had made a faux pas.

After our visit to Xian and a farewell ceremony in Beijing with Chairman Zhao that marked the close of the official part of our visit, we flew to Shanghai, where we toured a factory China was modernizing with the help of U.S. technology, then spoke to students at a Shanghai university (where about half of the faculty members had attended school in America) and I made an address that was televised live in Shanghai. The next day, we went to the Rainbow Bridge commune (in a subtle indication of the changes that were under way in China, the “commune” in its name had recently been changed to “township”), where we visited a private home in which a young couple lived with their small boy and the husband’s father and mother. After years of saving money, the husband had built the house himself and